

The Instability Itself Is the Institution: Ministerial Survival and Institutional Learning in Peru, 1821–2026

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Abstract

Why do political systems that change so much change so little in how they govern? This paper addresses that question through an original dataset of 1,062 ministerial spells covering five portfolios in Peru from 1821 to 2026. Rather than treating ministerial duration as the outcome to be explained, we treat it as a signal: an observable trace of the continuity conditions under which governing experience either accumulates into institutional knowledge or is repeatedly lost. We organize the analysis around two analytical heuristics. The first is the institutional epoch — the path-dependent period between critical junctures — which captures whether successive historical ruptures produced durable improvements in continuity conditions. The second is the protective belt — a localized architecture of external accountability relationships that, where it exists, insulates certain ministries from the political logic governing the rest of the cabinet. Kaplan–Meier survival curves, log-rank tests, and Cox proportional hazards models show that epochs explain ministerial survival far better than individual traits or portfolio membership, and that continuity conditions did not improve monotonically across two centuries. The largest shift in the data occurred between the Oligarchic State and the Power-Sharing epoch; the most recent democratic period represents a partial regression toward the founding pattern of chronic interruption. The protective belt emerges only after 1993, when external accountability structures raised the cost of Economy minister replacement beyond what domestic political pressure alone could sustain. The central theoretical finding is that chronic ministerial instability in Peru is not evidence of absent institutions but of a durable informal one: the escape valve through which political pressure is absorbed without producing structural change. The instability itself is the institution.

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“Se vogliamo che tutto rimanga
com’è, bisogna che tutto cambi.”

Il Gattopardo
Giuseppe Tomasi di Lampedusa,
1958

Introduction

Governing is hard. Education, health, and public safety are not technical problems with known solutions — they are complex social challenges that resist quick fixes and demand sustained institutional effort. Good policy takes time to design, time to

implement, and more time still to reach the people it is meant to serve. Good practices percolate gradually. Organizations learn slowly. Citizens feel change only after years of consistent effort in the same direction. In the big picture, where governance improved, it did so through institutional correction after crisis — converting rupture into consolidation, learning from failure rather than repeating it.

After more than two hundred years of republican life, the Peruvian political class has repeatedly changed governments, cabinets, constitutions, and political coalitions. Yet the underlying pattern remains remarkably stable. Each new administration appoints a cabinet whose members understand, implicitly or explicitly, the terms of their engagement: they are expected to manage complexity on behalf of the leader, but they may also be sacrificed whenever political pressure demands a visible response. Their departure rarely resolves the conflict that triggered it. The resignation of a premier or any other minister may relieve immediate pressure, but it seldom addresses the underlying causes of crisis. Cabinet reshuffles signal responsiveness without necessarily producing institutional correction.

This persistence should not be mistaken for an absence of learning. Political actors adapt continuously. Over time, they have become increasingly adept at navigating constitutional ambiguities, managing blame, and deploying ministerial replacement as a mechanism for absorbing public dissatisfaction. If the political class has learned anything, it has been how to reproduce the system's response to crisis rather than how to transform it. Governments change. Ministers change. The repertoire through which instability is managed remains largely intact. This cycle has marked much of Peru's republican history.

This vicious circle is generally called path dependence — a sophisticated way to say that the inertia of accumulated choices makes deviation increasingly costly and increasingly unlikely. And yet paths do break. Oxford philosopher Roman Krznaric (2024) argues that radical change requires what he calls the disruption nexus: a crisis, disruptive movements that amplify it, and powerful ideas that are ready to fill the space the crisis opens. France's Fifth Republic had all three: the Algerian War as crisis, De Gaulle's movement as disruptive force, and a constitutional design — the strong executive — as the idea ready to be deployed. It was not one event that broke France's path. It was a multigenerational accumulation of chronic instability that the Third and Fourth Republics never resolved. The Fifth Republic became the enduring legacy of a critical juncture in French history. More importantly, it appears to have altered the conditions under which political continuity was produced. The result was not merely institutional change, but a durable shift in the patterns of executive stability that had characterized French politics for more than a century.

France, before the Fifth Republic, was not very different from Peru during the previous hundred years. Both experienced remarkably high levels of executive instability, reflected in similar numbers of premier appointments per decade. Figure 1 tells the story visually. Peru peaked at 23 appointments in the 1890s; France reached 20 in the 1930s. Yet the advent of the Fifth Republic in 1958 initiated sharply diverging

trajectories. French premier appointments fell to a stable band of three to six per decade and have remained there ever since, while Peru is returning to levels observed in the nineteenth century. Peru has experienced no shortage of potential disruption nexuses — or, as we will later call them, critical junctures: independence without state-building, the War of the Pacific, hyperinflation, terrorism, the fall of Fujimori, and a permanent constitutional crisis since 2016. Each represented a moment in which alternative institutional trajectories became plausible.

The question, however, is not whether institutional change occurred. Peru’s republican history is full of reforms, constitutions, regime transitions, and political ruptures. The question is whether those ruptures produced institutional learning. By institutional learning, we mean the capacity of an institutional order to generate more favorable conditions for preserving, accumulating, and transmitting political experience over time. From this perspective, a critical juncture is successful not simply because it produces a new institutional arrangement, but because it leaves behind a legacy that alters how the system responds to future crises. France appears to have experienced such a transformation after 1958. Peru’s trajectory raises the possibility that institutional change and institutional learning do not necessarily coincide.

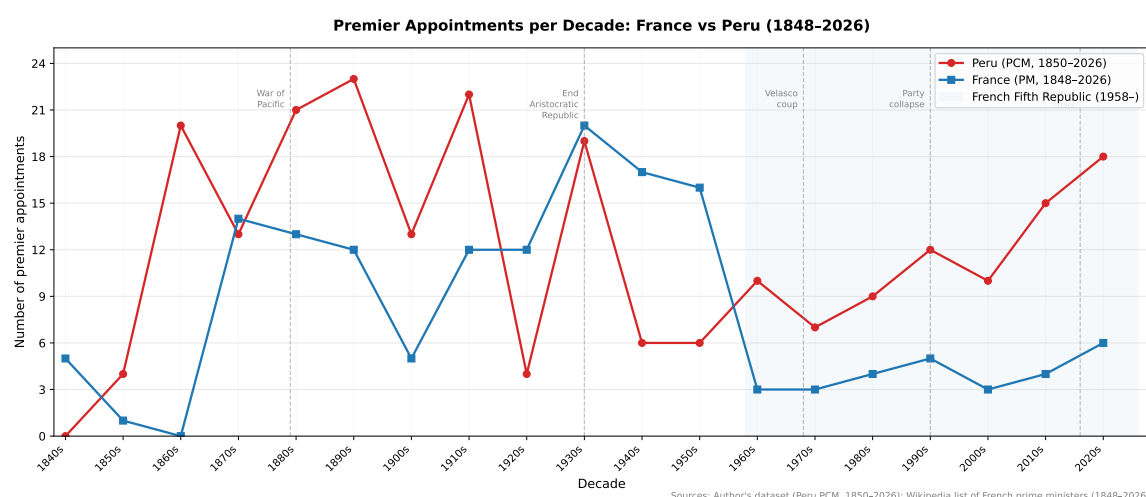


Figure 1

Premier Appointments per Decade: France vs. Peru, 1848–2026.

Sources: Author's dataset (based on Gálvez Montero and García Vega (2016a, 2016b)); Wikipedia list of French prime ministers (1848–2026).

I approach institutional learning through ministerial duration data using the heuristic of institutional epochs. Within epochs, duration provides evidence about the conditions under which knowledge accumulates; across epochs, changes in those patterns provide evidence about institutional learning. Political science has traditionally studied these phenomena separately. Ministerial duration has been analyzed through the tools of survival and event-history analysis, while institutional change has been

examined through the comparative-historical literature on critical junctures and path dependence. This paper combines both traditions. It uses ministerial duration data to evaluate whether critical junctures produced enduring changes in the conditions under which political experience accumulates.

The *epoch* heuristic is the institutional period that encompasses one or more presidential administrations and is defined by the critical junctures that periodically restructure the state's political logic. Epochs capture what neither individual traits nor political context alone can explain: the continuity conditions under which experience is either accumulated or repeatedly lost. If institutional learning occurs, it should be observable through changes in those conditions across successive epochs.

Within epochs, this work conceptualizes a second analytical heuristic, the *protective belt*: an *ad hoc* architecture of rules, actors, and external accountability relationships that, where it exists, helps preserve continuity despite the political logic governing the rest of the cabinet. By protecting continuity, the belt creates opportunities for knowledge accumulation within epochs and may allow certain sectors to function as islands of institutional effectiveness within a broader environment of instability. The protective belt does not explain institutional learning at the level of the state as a whole. Rather, it explains why some ministries may accumulate knowledge and preserve continuity even when the broader institutional environment remains unfavorable.

The question guiding this study is straightforward: *Have Peru's critical junctures ever produced institutional learning?*

This question cannot be answered directly. Institutional learning is not observed in the data. Instead, the study approaches the question indirectly through patterns of ministerial duration. If institutional learning improves the conditions under which political experience accumulates and is preserved, then such improvements should be reflected in changes in ministerial continuity across institutional epochs. Ministerial duration therefore provides an approximate indicator of the continuity conditions from which institutional learning may emerge.

The theoretical framework developed in this paper distinguishes between knowledge accumulation within institutional epochs and institutional learning across them. This distinction allows the central question to be translated into three empirical questions that can be addressed with duration data. *First*, what continuity conditions for knowledge accumulation characterized each institutional epoch? *Second*, did those continuity conditions change across successive epochs in ways consistent with institutional learning, or did critical junctures repeatedly reproduce the same underlying pattern of ministerial instability? *Third*, do some sectors of the state systematically escape the continuity conditions of their epoch, exhibiting survival patterns consistent with the presence of a protective belt, and if so, what does their existence reveal about the broader dynamics of continuity, knowledge accumulation, and institutional effectiveness?

To answer these questions, we construct an original dataset of individual min-

isterial spells covering the period from 1821 to 2026. The dataset includes the portfolios most relevant to the argument developed here: the premier, who coordinates the cabinet and sustains the political viability of the executive; the economy minister, whose decisions shape the state’s fiscal and investment capacity; and the ministers of Interior, Health, and Education, whose portfolios address some of the most consequential and persistent public challenges facing the country, according to official yearly surveys (INEI, 2024). The spells are organized into six institutional epochs defined by the critical junctures that periodically restructured Peru’s political logic (Lopez Jimenez et al., 2025). Combining descriptive analysis with survival models, the study evaluates whether patterns of ministerial continuity reveal different conditions for knowledge accumulation within epochs, whether those conditions changed across successive epochs, and whether some sectors exhibit continuity patterns consistent with the presence of a protective belt.

1 Literature Review

The political science literature on ministerial survival has converged around two broad families of explanations. The first emphasizes the characteristics of ministers themselves. The second emphasizes the political and institutional environments within which ministers operate. Table 1 summarizes the principal covariates identified across the core studies.

1.1 Trait-Based Explanations of Ministerial Survival

Trait-based approaches explain ministerial survival through characteristics of the officeholder. Across different institutional settings, scholars have shown that ministers’ professional backgrounds, political careers, partisan affiliations, and personal resources influence their probability of remaining in office. Early studies emphasized broad distinctions between managerial and parliamentary profiles, as well as the effects of career trajectories and prior political experience (Blondel, 1988). Subsequent work expanded the range of relevant characteristics to include age, education, gender, portfolio rank, and seniority within government (Dewan & Dowding, 2005; Fischer et al., 2012).

More recent research has refined these categories by focusing on the organizational and political resources that ministers bring to office. Feliú Ribeiro and López Burian show that technical expertise and membership in presidential networks increase ministerial survival, while prior electoral experience may paradoxically operate as a risk factor (Feliú Ribeiro & López Burian, 2023). Across four Latin American countries between 1945 and 2020, career politicians proved more vulnerable to dismissal than technocrats. The finding suggests that ministerial value cannot be reduced to political experience alone; survival depends on the type of resources that political leaders seek to preserve.

Table 1*Trait-based and Context-based Predictors of Ministerial Survival*

Author(s)	Trait-based	Context-based
Blondel (1988)	Career duration; parliamentary vs. managerial profile	Party system norms; head-of-government style; country context
Huber & Martínez-Gallardo (2008)	Ideological distance from government center; PM party membership; portfolio importance	Coalition type; minority government; electoral volatility; party fractionalization
Dewan & Dowding (2005)	Resignation issue salience; ministerial seniority	PM support level; media attention; single-party vs. coalition system
Fischer et al. (2012)	Age; education; gender; portfolio rank	PM popularity; regime type; frequency of resignation calls
Camerlo & Pérez-Liñán (2015)	Portfolio type; technocrat/partisan/outsider profile; first cabinet appointment	Protests; scandals; electoral calendar; term limits; reelection rules
Camerlo & Castaldo (2024)	Partisan rank within party hierarchy (leader, high-rank, low-rank, newcomer, shadow, defector)	Party government model applicability; regime type; party institutionalization level
Feliú Ribeiro & López Burian (2023)	Technical expertise; presidential group membership; prior electoral experience (<i>risk factor</i>)	Economic growth; GDP per capita; legislative powers; regime type; portfolio area
Mejía et al. (2021)	Education; gender; regional origin; prior elected office	Coalition type; legislative majority; party system change
Alexiadou & Gunaydin (2019)	Technocratic profile; non-partisan status; reform commitment	Economic crisis severity; electoral system type; party control of portfolio
Baturo & Elkins (2014)	Personal traits as time-invariant officeholder effects (education, prior career)	Regime institutionalization; personalization vs. office-based authority
Jara Iñiguez & Cedeño Alcívar (2019)	Managerial performance lifecycle (inverted-U over tenure)	Presidential appointment and dismissal capacity; political trust as selection criterion

The literature has also moved beyond simple dichotomies between partisan and non-partisan ministers. Camerlo and Castaldo argue that partisan affiliation conceals substantial variation in the strength of a minister's relationship with the party organization. Their framework distinguishes among leaders, high-ranks, low-ranks, newcomers, shadows, and defectors according to levels of engagement, consolidation, and hierarchical position within the party (Camerlo & Castaldo, 2024). Applied to the Argentine cabinet under Alberto Fernández, this approach reveals that apparently strong partisan cabinets may actually consist of ministers with limited organizational leverage over their parties (Camerlo et al., 2024). For survival analysis, the implication is straightforward: ministers classified under the same partisan label may possess very different capacities to resist political pressure.

Taken together, these studies demonstrate that ministerial duration is shaped by who ministers are. Technical expertise, organizational embeddedness, political experience, and personal resources all influence survival prospects. Yet the significance of these traits depends on the environments in which ministers operate. The same characteristic may be rewarded in one institutional setting and penalized in another. This observation leads to the second major family of explanations.

1.2 Context-Based Explanations of Ministerial Survival

Context-based approaches explain ministerial survival through characteristics of the political environment rather than characteristics of individual ministers. In this perspective, ministers survive or fail because of the institutional and political constraints surrounding them.

The comparative literature consistently identifies coalition dynamics as a central determinant of ministerial duration. Coalition type, minority government status, electoral volatility, and party-system fragmentation all shape the likelihood of ministerial replacement independently of individual characteristics (Huber & Martínez-Gallardo, 2008). Similarly, political crises, scandals, protests, electoral calendars, and term limits alter the incentives presidents face when deciding whether to retain or dismiss ministers (Alexiadou & Gunaydin, 2019; Camerlo & Pérez-Liñán, 2015). Even macroeconomic performance influences survival probabilities by modifying the broader political environment within which governments operate (Feliú Ribeiro & López Burian, 2023).

The case literature illustrates these mechanisms particularly clearly. For Colombia, Mejía Guinand et al. find that individual characteristics matter, but the institutional configuration of the political system ultimately determines the range within which those characteristics can operate (Mejía et al., 2021). Constitutional reforms, changes in party-system structure, and coalition arrangements alter the political logic governing ministerial careers. A similar conclusion emerges from Chile. Avendaño and Dávila show that ministerial turnover during the Concertación governments was driven primarily by coalition management considerations rather than by individual performance. Finance ministers consistently exhibited the longest tenures regardless of personal characteristics (Avendaño & Dávila, 2012).

Recent work has also refined the contextual analysis of ministerial portfolios. Portfolio importance has traditionally been measured through expert rankings that assign ministries a single level of salience. Camerlo and Martínez-Gallardo argue that such measures obscure important differences among ministries, particularly in contexts characterized by weak party institutionalization (Camerlo & Gallardo, 2022). Their framework decomposes ministerial value into policy-management capacity, discretionary resource allocation, political agenda influence, and inter-portfolio coordination authority. Different political environments activate different dimensions of portfolio value, producing distinct survival incentives for presidents and ministers alike.

Taken together, these studies show that ministerial survival depends not only on who ministers are but also on where they operate. Institutional structures, coalition arrangements, political crises, economic conditions, and portfolio characteristics shape the opportunities and constraints governing ministerial careers.

1.3 Reinterpreting Ministerial Duration

The two families of explanations are not competing research programs. Virtually every study combines individual and contextual covariates, with political environments conditioning the effects of ministerial traits. The resulting literature has generated a rich understanding of why some ministers survive longer than others.

What the literature has not asked is a prior question: what patterns of survival reveal about the continuity conditions through which political experience is collectively preserved, accumulated, and transmitted over time. Existing studies treat duration as the outcome to be explained. This paper treats duration as evidence about the institutional conditions that sustain continuity. Rather than asking why one minister survives longer than another, we ask what patterns of ministerial continuity reveal about the environments within which political experience can accumulate over time.

The next section develops a theoretical framework linking continuity, knowledge accumulation, and institutional learning, and introduces critical junctures and institutional epochs as the analytical devices through which those processes can be studied historically.

2 Theoretical Framework

2.1 From Ministerial Survival to Institutional Learning

The literature reviewed above treats ministerial survival as the outcome to be explained. Most studies seek to account for variation in survival across individual appointments by focusing on ministers' personal characteristics, political context, or the interaction between the two. This paper asks a different question. Rather than explaining variation among ministers, it examines variation within and between institutional epochs. The objective is not to determine why one minister survives longer than another, but what patterns of survival reveal about the continuity conditions characterizing a particular institutional order.

What survival time carries, we argue, is information about a prior and more consequential process: the accumulation of institutional knowledge within the state. A foundational claim of organizational learning theory is that institutions outperform alternatives when they successfully encode inferences from experience into routines that guide future behavior (Levitt & March, 1988, pp. 319–320). For this to occur, experience must first persist long enough to be accumulated, shared, and embedded within organizations. Ministerial stability is therefore not valuable in itself. Rather, it constitutes a necessary condition for the accumulation of knowledge from which broader processes of institutional learning may subsequently emerge (Nonaka, 1998).

For the purposes of this paper, it is useful to distinguish between **knowledge accumulation** and **institutional learning**. The former refers to the process through which experience is retained, articulated, shared, and embedded within organizations. The latter refers to the capacity of an institutional order to generate

progressively more favorable conditions for the accumulation, retention, and transmission of experience over time. The two concepts are related but distinct. Knowledge accumulation occurs within organizations. Institutional learning refers to changes in the broader conditions under which such accumulation becomes possible.

This distinction draws on a common insight running through the literature reviewed below. For Nonaka, learning requires the successful conversion of experience into organizational knowledge (Nonaka, 1998). For Simon, organizations learn when they develop more effective ways of structuring and responding to complex problems (Foss & Foss, 2005). For Allison, learning becomes visible when experience is embedded in routines that guide future action (Allison, 1969). Across these perspectives, learning implies more than isolated episodes of knowledge creation. It implies the development of conditions that allow experience to be retained and used rather than repeatedly lost.

The distinction becomes particularly important when considering what ministerial duration can and cannot reveal. Ministerial duration is not treated as a direct measure of either knowledge accumulation or institutional learning. A long ministerial tenure does not demonstrate that knowledge accumulated, just as a short tenure does not prove that accumulation failed. Rather, duration is interpreted as an observable indicator of continuity. Continuity creates opportunities for knowledge accumulation. Institutional learning, by contrast, becomes visible when institutional orders generate more favorable conditions for such accumulation over time. What patterns of duration reveal, therefore, is not learning itself but the extent to which institutional continuity creates opportunities for experience to accumulate.

Consequently, the objective of this study is not to determine whether individual ministers learned, nor whether particular appointments were successful. Instead, it evaluates whether patterns of ministerial continuity reveal opportunities for knowledge accumulation within the state. Ministerial duration serves as an observable indicator of continuity. The question is not why ministers survive, but what patterns of ministerial duration reveal about the state's capacity to preserve and accumulate experience over time.

The remainder of the theoretical framework develops this argument in three steps. First, it explains the mechanisms through which continuity enables knowledge accumulation within institutional settings. Second, it examines how continuity conditions can be compared historically through the concepts of critical junctures and institutional epochs, and how such comparisons may be interpreted as evidence of institutional learning. Third, it introduces the concept of the protective belt to explain why some ministries may experience continuity conditions that differ from those prevailing in the broader institutional environment.

The framework distinguishes between causal mechanisms, contextual conditions, mediating processes, and observable indicators. Not all elements discussed below are directly observed in the data; some function as latent theoretical constructs whose existence is assessed indirectly through their observable implications. Through-

out the discussion, **arrows** ($\rightarrow$) are used as heuristic representations of hypothesized causal influence. They indicate a proposed direction of influence but do not imply a specific sign, magnitude, or deterministic effect.

2.2 Knowledge Accumulation Within Epochs

Having established continuity as the central mechanism linking ministerial duration to knowledge accumulation, the next theoretical task is to explain how that accumulation occurs. What mechanisms allow governing experience to accumulate, and what mechanisms interrupt that process?

The argument developed here begins with a simple proposition: continuity creates the conditions under which knowledge accumulation becomes possible. Drawing on Nonaka, knowledge creation is not a single event but a cumulative process through which tacit knowledge becomes explicit, is shared within the organization, and is eventually internalized into routines and practices (Nonaka, 1998). New knowledge emerges through repeated interaction among organizational members, the articulation of experience into formal procedures, and the gradual incorporation of those procedures into everyday behavior. The process cannot be compressed into a single decision, nor can it survive repeated interruptions without loss.

$$\text{Continuity} \rightarrow \text{Knowledge Accumulation} \quad (1)$$

Proposition 1 is further reinforced by Cohen, March, and Olsen's theory of *organized anarchy*. Organized anarchies are characterized by problematic preferences, unclear technology, and *fluid participation* (Cohen et al., 1972). Applied to cabinet politics, fluid participation resembles the absence of continuity: decision-makers are replaced before they can develop a shared understanding of the problems they were appointed to address. Under such conditions, the shared cognitive environment required for retaining, articulating, and transmitting experience becomes difficult to sustain. In this sense, fluid participation provides an alternative theoretical justification for the central claim that continuity creates opportunities for knowledge accumulation over time.

Proposition 1 is also reinforced by Simon's theory of bounded rationality. Complex policy problems initially present themselves as ill-structured and become manageable only through gradual processes of problem decomposition and constraint formation (Foss & Foss, 2005, pp. 4–5). When ministers confront complex social challenges, their understanding is initially tacit and incomplete. For organizations to benefit from that experience, tacit knowledge must be articulated, codified, and transformed into explicit knowledge that can be communicated and shared. This transformation requires time. Premature dismissal interrupts the conversion process, leaving experience personal rather than organizational and thereby limiting opportunities for knowledge accumulation.

Proposition 1 receives further support from Allison's organizational process perspective. Governments confront recurring problems through routines and standard operating procedures developed from prior experience (Allison, 1969). Once knowledge has been articulated and formalized, it must be repeatedly applied before it becomes embedded in organizational routines. Chronic turnover disrupts this final stage by preventing newly created knowledge from stabilizing within organizational practice.

From this perspective, organizational routines constitute the institutional repository through which accumulated knowledge survives individual officeholders and becomes available to future decision-makers.

Taken together, these perspectives converge on a common conclusion. Cohen, March, and Olsen explain why the social conditions required for knowledge creation may never emerge. Simon explains why the articulation of knowledge requires sustained attention to complex problems. Allison explains why newly created knowledge must be embedded in routines before organizations can benefit from it. Nonaka provides the overarching framework connecting these processes. Across all four perspectives, Proposition 1 captures the central mechanism of knowledge accumulation within epochs: continuity enables the retention, articulation, and transmission of experience, while chronic turnover repeatedly interrupts these processes.

2.3 Institutional Learning Between Epochs

As established in Proposition 1, continuity facilitates the retention and transmission of experience within organizations. Institutional learning, however, concerns whether the conditions governing that continuity change over time. Institutional learning becomes visible when successive institutional epochs generate increasingly favorable conditions for continuity.

Interpreting continuity historically therefore requires a framework capable of identifying when the institutional conditions governing political life have changed. The same observed duration may imply very different continuity conditions depending on the political logic, constraints, and expectations characterizing a particular historical period. Continuity cannot be evaluated against a universal benchmark; it must be interpreted relative to the institutional environment in which it is produced. For this reason, the analysis requires historically bounded units through which continuity can be compared across periods.

Comparing continuity across time requires a framework capable of identifying when the institutional logic governing political life has been fundamentally restructured. The comparative-historical literature provides such a framework through the concept of the critical juncture.

$$\text{Institutional Epoch} \rightarrow \text{Continuity} \rightarrow \text{Institutional Learning} \quad (2)$$

Proposition 2 states the central claim of this section: institutional learning is not inferred from institutional change alone, but from whether successive epochs generate more favorable conditions for continuity than those that preceded them.

Critical junctures are defined as relatively short periods of time during which there is a substantially heightened probability that agents' choices will affect the outcome of interest (Capoccia & Kelemen, 2007, p. 348). These brief moments of structural fluidity are followed by long periods of path-dependent institutional reproduction, in which the choices made during the juncture become increasingly difficult to reverse. The standard application of this framework identifies a formal institution created or transformed at the juncture and traces its reproduction across the subsequent path. For our purposes, the implication is theoretical: if knowledge accumulates or is repeatedly interrupted within institutional periods, then the appropriate historical unit is the epoch — the path-dependent phase between critical junctures — rather than the presidential administration or the individual ministerial spell.

Capoccia introduces a further concept that proves essential for the framework: the near-miss critical juncture. Because critical junctures are defined by contingency — by what happened in the context of what could have happened — it is entirely possible for a crisis to produce a moment of genuine institutional openness that is ultimately resolved through re-equilibration rather than change (Capoccia & Kelemen, 2007, pp. 350–351). The previous institutional arrangement is reinstated, often in modified form, and the path continues. Critical junctures may therefore fail to alter the conditions governing knowledge accumulation. Institutional change can occur without a corresponding transformation in learning conditions.

This observation creates a theoretical puzzle. If formal institutions are repeatedly transformed, disrupted, or replaced, in what sense can one speak of path dependence at all? Levitsky and Murillo argue that in much of the developing world actors develop expectations of instability rather than expectations of institutional reproduction (Levitsky & Murillo, 2009, p. 123). Yet from the perspective developed here, the relevant question is not whether formal institutions remain unchanged, but whether the conditions governing continuity and knowledge accumulation persist across time. Informal mechanisms may survive repeated formal transformations and thereby reproduce the same continuity conditions across successive epochs.

This distinction lies at the core of Proposition 2. Institutional learning is not inferred from the occurrence of institutional change itself, but from whether the legacies of change alter continuity in durable ways. A sequence of critical junctures followed by increasingly favorable continuity conditions would suggest institutional learning. A sequence of critical junctures followed by repeated interruptions or unchanged continuity conditions would suggest its absence. The key theoretical question is therefore whether successive institutional epochs generated different opportunities for continuity and, consequently, for knowledge accumulation.

2.4 The Exception That Tests the Rule: The Protective Belt

The previous sections described the general mechanisms governing knowledge accumulation within epochs and institutional learning across them. Yet the continuity described in Proposition 1 is not necessarily distributed uniformly across ministerial portfolios. Some ministries may experience survival patterns that differ systematically from those prevailing in the broader institutional environment. Explaining such variation requires an additional mechanism.

The concept proposed here is the Protective Belt¹. The belt functions as a buffer that absorbs pressures that would otherwise interrupt continuity. It consists of informal rules, external actors, and accountability relationships that raise the political cost of ministerial replacement and thereby reduce the likelihood that continuity will be interrupted.

The protective belt is not necessarily associated with the same ministry across time. Because critical junctures reshape the institutional logic of an epoch, they may also alter which ministerial functions are considered most critical for the stability and reproduction of the prevailing order. Consequently, different epochs may generate protective belts around different sectors. The object of protection is therefore expected to vary historically according to the dominant threats, audiences, and accountability relationships characterizing each institutional epoch.

$$\text{Protective Belt} \rightarrow \text{Continuity} \rightarrow \text{Knowledge Accumulation} \quad (3)$$

Proposition 3 specifies a localized mechanism through which continuity may be preserved within a particular portfolio, even when broader institutional conditions remain unfavorable to continuity.

Comparative evidence suggests that such protection may emerge around specific portfolios under particular accountability structures. Feliú Ribeiro and López Burian demonstrate that foreign policy portfolios survive significantly longer than domestic portfolios across Latin America (Feliú Ribeiro & López Burian, 2023). The mechanism they identify is external accountability. International audiences create credibility costs that presidents must absorb when replacing ministers, thereby increasing continuity independently of domestic political pressures.

The protective belt is therefore not a veto player, nor a form of social capital. It is a cost structure that alters the incentives surrounding ministerial replacement. Its presence or absence determines whether the continuity conditions experienced by a ministry differ from those prevailing in the broader institutional environment.

The Protective Belt does not explain institutional learning at the level of the state as a whole. Rather, it explains why some ministries may accumulate knowledge

¹The term "protective belt" is borrowed from Lakatos's philosophy of science, where it refers to a surrounding structure that shields a program's core assumptions from immediate falsification (Lakatos, 1978). The concept is used here metaphorically to denote institutional arrangements that protect continuity from political pressures.

and preserve continuity even when broader learning conditions remain unfavorable. It is a localized continuity-preserving mechanism that may create islands of effectiveness without altering the broader learning conditions of the institutional order.

3 Research Design and Analytical Strategy

The theoretical framework developed in the previous chapter proposes three related propositions. Proposition 1 argues that continuity creates opportunities for knowledge accumulation within institutional settings. Proposition 2 argues that institutional learning becomes visible when successive institutional epochs generate more favorable continuity conditions. Proposition 3 identifies the protective belt as a localized mechanism through which continuity may be preserved within specific ministerial portfolios.

These propositions raise an immediate methodological challenge. Neither knowledge accumulation, institutional learning, nor protective belts can be observed directly. They are theoretical constructs whose existence must be assessed indirectly through observable implications. The research design therefore distinguishes between a historical-institutionalist layer, which provides the interpretive framework through which continuity acquires meaning, and a measurement layer, which identifies the observable indicators used to evaluate continuity empirically.

The research design is organized around two complementary layers. The first is a historical-institutionalist layer that provides the contextual framework through which continuity acquires historical meaning. The second is a measurement layer that translates the theoretical concepts developed in the previous chapter into observable indicators and empirical comparisons. Building on these two layers, the chapter derives the analytical expectations associated with each proposition, presents the statistical procedures used to evaluate them, and concludes by discussing the scope and limitations of the design.

3.1 From Theory to Observation

The theoretical framework centers on continuity as the mechanism connecting ministerial duration to broader processes of knowledge accumulation and institutional learning. Continuity itself, however, is not directly observable. What can be observed are the durations of ministerial appointments. The empirical challenge is therefore to determine whether patterns of ministerial duration provide useful information about the continuity conditions under which political experience may be retained, transmitted, or interrupted.

This distinction is fundamental. Ministerial duration is not treated as a direct measure of knowledge accumulation, institutional learning, or governmental effectiveness. A minister who remains in office for three years may fail to learn, govern poorly, or leave no lasting institutional legacy. Conversely, a minister who serves for only a few months may contribute substantially to policy development. Duration therefore

Table 2*From Theoretical Concepts to Observable Evidence*

Concept		Status	Observable implication
Continuity		Inferred	Ministerial duration and survival patterns.
Knowledge Accumulation		Latent	Not directly observed; inferred from the continuity conditions identified within epochs (Proposition 1).
Institutional Learning		Latent	Not directly observed; interpreted through changes in continuity across institutional epochs (Proposition 2).
Protective Belt		Inferred	Systematic deviations in continuity across ministerial portfolios within the same epoch (Proposition 3).
Institutional Epoch		Observed	Historical periods derived from critical junctures and used as contextual units of comparison.

does not measure outcomes. Rather, it measures exposure to continuity. It indicates the amount of time available for organizational processes of learning, articulation, routinization, and transmission to occur.

For this reason, the analysis relies on a layered inferential strategy. Ministerial duration constitutes the observable indicator. Continuity represents the theoretical mechanism inferred from patterns of duration. Knowledge accumulation and institutional learning remain latent concepts whose plausibility is evaluated through the continuity conditions revealed by those patterns. The objective is not to observe learning directly, but to evaluate whether the institutional environment generated opportunities under which learning could plausibly emerge.

Table 2 identifies the empirical status of the principal theoretical concepts and the observable implications through which each proposition is evaluated.

This distinction implies that the empirical analysis should be interpreted cautiously. The evidence presented below does not demonstrate institutional learning directly. Rather, it evaluates the continuity conditions from which knowledge accumulation and institutional learning may emerge.

3.2 Historical-Institutionalist Layer

The theoretical framework argues that continuity acquires meaning only within a historical context. The same observed duration may indicate very different continuity conditions depending on the institutional environment in which it occurs. A

ministerial tenure lasting one year may represent exceptional stability in one period and chronic instability in another. Continuity therefore cannot be evaluated against a universal benchmark. It must be interpreted relative to the institutional epoch in which it is produced.

Institutional epochs provide the contextual framework required by Proposition 2. Following the critical-juncture literature, epochs are understood as path-dependent periods bounded by moments of institutional restructuring. Critical junctures themselves are not treated as explanatory variables in the statistical analysis. Rather, they provide the historical criteria used to delimit the periods within which continuity is interpreted and compared.

The analysis adopts the structural-historical periodization proposed by Lopez Jimenez et al. (2025). This periodization identifies epochs according to critical junctures that reconfigured the dominant logic of state organization and political competition. The resulting epochs are treated as historically bounded environments within which continuity conditions may differ systematically.

The use of epochs serves two analytical purposes. First, it allows continuity conditions to be examined within historically coherent institutional environments. Second, it permits comparisons across successive periods, thereby providing the basis for evaluating whether continuity improved, deteriorated, or remained unchanged over time. Under Proposition 2, institutional learning is assessed through these historical comparisons rather than through isolated observations of ministerial survival.

3.2.1 Operationalizing Institutional Epochs

Proposition 2 requires historically bounded units through which continuity can be compared across time. Following the historical-institutionalist framework developed in the previous chapter, these units are operationalized as institutional epochs. Critical junctures are not treated as explanatory variables in the statistical analysis. Rather, they provide the criteria used to delimit historically distinct institutional environments within which continuity is interpreted.

The periodization adopted in this study follows Lopez Jimenez et al. (2025), who identify a sequence of critical junctures that restructured the dominant logic of state organization, political competition, and social incorporation in Peru. Each resulting epoch is treated as a distinct contextual environment governing the continuity conditions under which political experience may be retained, transmitted, or interrupted.

Table 3 summarizes the institutional epochs employed in the analysis.

The epochs summarized above are not merely chronological containers. Each represents a distinct institutional environment governing the continuity conditions under which political experience could be accumulated, transmitted, or interrupted. The critical-juncture column identifies the process that opened each epoch, while the cut-point column identifies the year used to delimit epochs in the empirical analysis. These cut points correspond to the completion of the critical juncture rather than to

Table 3

Institutional Epochs Used in the Analysis

Epoch	Period	End Point used	Critical Juncture	State and Democratization	Why It Ends
State Formation	1824–1879	1883	Independence (1810–1824). Liberal failure in state building; caudillo factionalism; colonial continuities intact.	Failed creole revolutions; indigenous participation conditioned on tribute abolition; no unified national state.	The War of the Pacific (1879) exposes the total absence of a functional national state.
Oligarchic State	1883–1920	1933	War with Chile (1879–1883). Humiliated elites; demonstrated inexistence of a functional state.	Patrimonial reconstruction under oligarchic-gamonalista alliance; “competitive oligarchy” excluding 98% of population; early anarchist labor movement.	Popular mobilizations and Leguía’s self-coup trigger the Crisis of the Aristocratic Republic (1920–1933).
Power-Sharing State	1933–1968	1975	Crisis of the Aristocratic Republic (1920–1933). Leguía, the 1930 recession, Haya, Mariátegui, assassination of Sánchez Cerro.	Tripartite system: oligarchy, APRA, and armed forces. After 1956, “convivencia” (APRA-oligarchy alliance); mass labor, peasant, and student movements emerge.	Social overflow and state paralysis trigger the Military Revolution (1968).
Transition and Democratic Crisis	1975–1992	1993	Military Revolution (1968–1975). Destroyed oligarchy and gamonalismo through agrarian reform; centralized the state.	Universal suffrage (1979 Constitution); democratization through Shining Path massacre; collapse of the United Left. Hyperinflation and state terrorism against insurgency.	Absolute crisis of political parties, hyperinflation, and terrorist violence culminate in Fujimori’s self-coup (1992).
Democracy without Parties	1993–2022	2022	Terrorism crisis, hyperinflation, and Fujimori’s coup (1982–1992).	1993 Constitution; consolidated neoliberal model and neopatrimonial state; long commodity export boom legitimizes the arrangement. Democracy without parties; extreme electoral volatility; <i>outsider</i> politics.	Political fall of Pedro Castillo (2022), condensing 30 years of discontent with the neoliberal model, opens the Sixth Critical Juncture.

Source: Adapted from Lopez Jimenez et al. (2025). Cut points indicate the years used to delimit epochs in the empirical analysis. The political fall of Pedro Castillo in 2022 is treated as the beginning of an ongoing sixth critical juncture whose long-term institutional legacy remains unresolved.

its onset, ensuring continuous temporal coverage of ministerial spells while avoiding the assignment of transitional years to a stable institutional order.

Operationalizing epochs in this manner serves two analytical purposes. First, it allows continuity patterns to be evaluated within historically coherent institutional environments. Second, it permits comparisons across successive epochs, thereby providing the empirical basis for evaluating Proposition 2. If institutional learning occurred across Peru’s republican history, it should be reflected in increasingly favorable continuity conditions across successive epochs. Conversely, the persistence of similar patterns of interruption across epochs would suggest the absence of such learning.

Because the political consequences of the 2022 crisis remain unresolved, the post-2022 period is not treated as a consolidated institutional epoch. Instead, it is interpreted as an ongoing critical juncture whose long-term effects on continuity conditions cannot yet be assessed.

Alternative periodizations based on constitutional change or regime type were considered but ultimately rejected. Constitutional dates capture formal institutional ruptures that do not necessarily correspond to durable transformations in continuity conditions. Likewise, regime classifications collapse substantial variation within democratic and authoritarian periods into broad categories that are not central to the argument developed here. Because the theoretical framework focuses on continuity rather than formal institutional arrangements, the structural-historical periodization proposed by Lopez Jimenez et al. (2025) provides a more appropriate basis for identifying historically distinct institutional environments.

3.3 Measurement Layer

The measurement layer translates the theoretical concept of continuity into an observable quantity. The indicator employed throughout the analysis is ministerial duration, defined as the uninterrupted period during which an individual occupies a cabinet portfolio.

A ministerial spell begins on the date of appointment and ends on the date of departure, whether through dismissal, resignation, death in office, or the termination of the administration. Each uninterrupted period of service constitutes a distinct observation. When the same individual serves multiple non-consecutive terms, each appointment is treated as a separate spell because each represents a distinct opportunity for continuity and knowledge accumulation.

Duration is measured as the number of days elapsed between entry and exit from office. This measure is particularly appropriate because the theoretical framework does not seek to evaluate ministers as individuals. Rather, it seeks to evaluate the continuity conditions under which governing experience may be retained or interrupted. Duration therefore functions as an indicator of exposure to continuity rather than as an indicator of performance.

Within the framework developed in Section 2, duration informs three distinct analytical comparisons. Within epochs, variation in duration provides evidence about opportunities for knowledge accumulation under a given institutional order. Between epochs, changes in duration patterns provide evidence about changes in continuity conditions and, therefore, about the plausibility of institutional learning. Across portfolios, systematic deviations from broader continuity patterns provide evidence consistent with the existence of protective belts.

The empirical analysis that follows is therefore organized around a simple inferential chain. Duration is observed. Continuity is inferred. Knowledge accumulation and institutional learning are interpreted through the continuity conditions revealed by those observations.

3.3.1 *Data and Units of Analysis*

The empirical analysis relies on an original dataset of ministerial appointments covering Peru's republican history from 1827 to 2022. The dataset records the entry

Table 4*Analytical Levels of the Study*

Proposition	Primary son	Compara-	Observable Evidence
Proposition 1	Within epochs	institutional	Variation in ministerial duration and survival patterns.
Proposition 2	Between epochs	institutional	Changes in continuity across succes- sive historical periods.
Proposition 3	Across ministerial port- folios		Persistent deviations in continuity relative to epoch-specific patterns.

and exit dates of cabinet ministers, the portfolio occupied, the administration under which the appointment occurred, and the institutional epoch to which each ministerial spell is assigned.

The primary unit of observation is the **ministerial spell**. A spell is defined as a continuous period during which an individual occupies a particular cabinet portfolio. The unit is chosen because continuity, the central mechanism identified in Proposition 1, operates through uninterrupted tenure rather than through individual characteristics alone. When the same individual serves multiple non-consecutive terms, each appointment constitutes a separate spell because each represents a distinct opportunity for continuity and knowledge accumulation.

The unit of analysis varies according to the proposition under consideration. For Proposition 1, individual ministerial spells provide evidence regarding continuity within institutional epochs. For Proposition 2, ministerial spells are aggregated within epochs to evaluate whether continuity conditions changed across historical periods. For Proposition 3, spells are grouped by ministerial portfolio to identify systematic deviations from broader continuity patterns.

The resulting design combines three analytical levels. The first examines variation among ministerial spells within a given epoch. The second compares aggregate continuity patterns across institutional epochs. The third compares continuity patterns across ministerial portfolios within the same historical context. Together, these levels allow the empirical analysis to evaluate continuity as an observable indicator while preserving the distinction between knowledge accumulation, institutional learning, and protective-belt effects established in the theoretical framework.

Table 4 summarizes the relationship between theoretical propositions, units of analysis, and empirical comparisons.

3.3.2 *Portfolio Selection*

The principal empirical analysis focuses on two ministerial portfolios: the Presidency of the Council of Ministers (Premier) and the Ministry of Economy and Finance (MEF). These portfolios were selected because they occupy distinct positions within the state's governing architecture and are exposed to different mechanisms affecting continuity.

The Premiership represents the political center of cabinet government. As the institution responsible for coordinating ministers and managing relations between the executive and the broader political system, it is particularly sensitive to changes in presidential strategy, coalition dynamics, legislative conflict, and cabinet reorganization. Continuity in the Premiership therefore provides a useful indicator of the political conditions governing ministerial survival.

The Ministry of Economy and Finance occupies a different institutional position. Although subject to presidential authority, the portfolio is often associated with technical expertise, fiscal credibility, and accountability to domestic and international economic actors. The political costs of replacing economic authorities may therefore differ from those affecting other ministries. As a result, continuity patterns in the MEF provide a theoretically relevant contrast to those observed in the Premiership.

Together, these portfolios capture two distinct dimensions of state governance: political coordination and economic management. Their comparison provides the principal empirical basis for evaluating continuity within and between institutional epochs.

Additional portfolios, including Interior, Education, and Health, are incorporated in later analyses exploring the possibility of protective-belt effects. These ministries are not used to establish the core historical patterns of continuity across epochs. Rather, they serve as comparative cases through which portfolio-specific deviations from broader continuity patterns can be identified.

This selection strategy follows the logic of the theoretical framework. Propositions 1 and 2 are evaluated primarily through the historical trajectories of the Premier and the MEF. Proposition 3, by contrast, requires comparison across portfolios and therefore motivates the inclusion of additional ministerial sectors. The distinction preserves continuity as the central analytical dimension while allowing portfolio-level variation to be examined where theoretically relevant.

3.3.3 *Operationalizing the Protective Belt*

Proposition 3 introduces the Protective Belt as a localized mechanism through which continuity may be preserved within particular ministerial portfolios. Unlike institutional epochs, however, protective belts are not directly observable. No historical record identifies when a ministry is formally protected from replacement pressures, nor is there a measurable indicator that directly captures the presence or absence of such protection.

The protective belt is therefore operationalized indirectly through its observable implications. If a protective belt exists around a particular portfolio, ministers occupying that portfolio should exhibit continuity patterns that differ systematically from those observed elsewhere in the cabinet. More specifically, portfolios benefiting from stronger protection should display longer ministerial durations and lower replacement rates than would be expected given the broader continuity conditions prevailing within the same institutional epoch.

This operationalization follows directly from Proposition 3. The protective belt itself remains an inferred construct. What can be observed are deviations from epoch-specific continuity patterns. Consequently, the empirical analysis does not seek to identify protective belts directly. Instead, it evaluates whether certain portfolios consistently display continuity advantages relative to other ministries operating under the same institutional environment.

The historical framework developed in the previous chapter further suggests that protective belts need not remain attached to the same portfolios across time. Because critical junctures reshape the institutional logic of an epoch, they may also alter which governmental functions become most essential for maintaining political stability, economic credibility, or external legitimacy. Consequently, the empirical analysis does not assume that a single ministry occupies a protected position throughout Peruvian history. Rather, it evaluates whether different portfolios emerge as continuity-preserving locations under different institutional conditions.

This operationalization implies that protective belts are evaluated comparatively rather than absolutely. A ministry is not considered protected because its ministers survive for a long time in isolation. Rather, protection is inferred when continuity within a portfolio systematically exceeds the continuity patterns characterizing other portfolios operating under comparable historical conditions. The object of analysis is therefore relative continuity rather than absolute duration.

3.4 Analytical Expectations

The theoretical framework generates three observable expectations corresponding to the propositions developed in Chapter 2.

The first expectation derives from Proposition 1. If continuity creates opportunities for knowledge accumulation, then institutional environments characterized by chronic interruption should exhibit shorter ministerial durations than environments characterized by greater continuity. Because knowledge accumulation itself remains unobserved, the empirical expectation concerns continuity rather than learning outcomes.

The second expectation derives from Proposition 2. If institutional learning occurs across historical periods, continuity should improve across successive institutional epochs. This expectation does not require monotonic improvement, nor does it imply that every critical juncture generates learning. Rather, it suggests that institutional learning would be consistent with a historical tendency toward more favorable

continuity conditions across time.

The third expectation derives from Proposition 3. If protective belts operate within particular ministerial portfolios, then some ministries should display continuity patterns that differ systematically from those prevailing elsewhere within the same epoch. Such differences should persist even when broader institutional conditions remain unfavorable.

These expectations define three corresponding levels of empirical comparison. The first compares continuity within institutional epochs. The second compares continuity across institutional epochs. The third compares continuity across ministerial portfolios. Together, these comparisons provide the empirical basis through which the theoretical propositions are evaluated.

3.5 Analytical Strategy

The empirical strategy employs methods from survival analysis to evaluate ministerial continuity. Survival analysis is particularly appropriate because the central observable quantity in this study is duration: the amount of time elapsed between ministerial appointment and departure from office.

The analysis proceeds in three stages.

First, descriptive survival functions are used to characterize continuity patterns within and across institutional epochs. Kaplan–Meier estimators provide non-parametric estimates of survival probabilities, allowing the persistence of ministerial appointments to be examined without imposing assumptions regarding the underlying distribution of duration.

Second, statistical comparisons between survival functions are used to evaluate whether continuity differs significantly across institutional epochs and ministerial portfolios. Log-rank tests provide a formal assessment of whether observed differences in survival patterns exceed what would be expected under a common survival process.

Third, semi-parametric Cox proportional hazards models are employed to estimate the relationship between institutional epochs, ministerial portfolios, and the risk of ministerial replacement. These models permit the simultaneous evaluation of historical context and portfolio effects while avoiding strong assumptions regarding the baseline hazard function.

The purpose of these procedures is not to identify the causes of individual ministerial survival. Existing literature has already demonstrated the importance of ministerial characteristics, political coalitions, presidential popularity, and contextual factors in shaping appointment outcomes. Instead, the objective is to evaluate whether continuity itself exhibits systematic variation within epochs, between epochs, and across ministerial portfolios.

Consequently, survival analysis functions here as a measurement tool rather than as a complete explanatory framework. It provides a rigorous method for evaluating continuity, the observable mechanism through which the broader theoretical

concepts of knowledge accumulation, institutional learning, and protective belts are interpreted.

3.6 Scope Conditions and Limitations

The research design rests on an important inferential distinction. Ministerial duration is directly observed, whereas continuity, knowledge accumulation, institutional learning, and protective belts are theoretical constructs inferred from observed patterns. The empirical analysis therefore evaluates the plausibility of these concepts through their observable implications rather than through direct measurement.

This limitation is particularly important for knowledge accumulation and institutional learning. The analysis does not observe whether ministers learned, whether organizations retained knowledge, or whether policy performance improved as a consequence of continuity. Such processes involve complex cognitive, organizational, and historical dynamics that cannot be reduced to a single quantitative indicator. Instead, the study evaluates whether continuity conditions existed under which such processes could plausibly occur.

A second limitation concerns institutional learning itself. Proposition 2 interprets learning historically rather than behaviorally. Institutional learning is inferred from changes in continuity across institutional epochs rather than from direct observation of organizational adaptation. Consequently, the conclusions drawn from the analysis should be understood as historical interpretations rather than direct measurements of learning.

Finally, protective belts remain inferred mechanisms. Their existence is evaluated through continuity patterns observed across ministerial portfolios rather than through direct evidence regarding the informal arrangements that may generate such protection. Identifying the precise political processes underlying those arrangements would require qualitative evidence beyond the scope of the present study.

These limitations do not invalidate the analysis. Rather, they define its scope. The contribution of the study lies not in directly measuring learning or knowledge accumulation, but in providing a systematic historical evaluation of the continuity conditions under which such processes may emerge.

4 Results

4.1 Continuity Conditions Within Institutional Epochs

4.2 Institutional Learning Between Epochs

4.3 The Protective Belt

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